SAMPLE PACK

Sample letters

What a family finds in their letterbox

Each letter is printed on one A4 sheet, double-sided. It is folded into a window envelope, so the family's address shows through the window. The letter is on the front, and the **Real history card** on the back gives the true facts behind it and a space for the child to write back.

In this pack

Page	Pen pal	To	Type	What to notice
2-3	**Mary Anning**	Oliver, 7	Introduction	The first letter a UK child receives. Victorian paper, a sketched ammonite, short sentences for a young reader
4-5	**Albert Einstein**	Maya, 9	Introduction	Typed on a typewriter. Connects to Maya's love of space and her cat, Biscuit
6-7	**Amelia Earhart**	Leo, 7	Reply	Answers Leo's own letter: "wer you scard?" and "what did you eat on the plane?"
8-9	**Cleopatra**	Sofia, 10	Introduction	Papyrus, "translated from the Greek". Ancient sources are explained honestly
10-11	**Leonardo da Vinci**	Sam, 11	Introduction	Parchment, a bird sketch, and a line of mirror writing to decode

How to read them

- **Personal:** the child's name and interests are woven in, never just listed.
- **True:** facts come only from each figure's verified fact sheet. The Real history card lists the facts, and marks anything imaginative as storytelling.
- **Safe:** no personal questions, no spoilers about the figure's own future, and nothing frightening for the child's age.
- **An invitation:** every letter ends with a P.S. question that's easy and fun to answer.

These samples were written from the same verified fact sheets the AI writer uses, to show the format and standard we expect. Live letters are written by the AI pipeline, checked by an independent AI fact-checker, and approved by our team before posting. The addresses are examples.

The Oliver Family
1 Example Street
Bristol
BS1 4ST

Lyme Regis, Dorset

Dear Oliver,

My name is Mary Anning, and I am writing to you from Lyme Regis, a little town by the sea in Dorset. I am told this letter will travel nearly two hundred years to reach you!

I hunt for fossils. After winter storms, rocks tumble down from the cliffs, and inside them I find the bones of creatures that lived long, long ago. When I was about twelve, I dug out the skeleton of a huge sea reptile called an ichthyosaur. Its name means fish-lizard!

I hear you love dinosaurs. So do I! My ichthyosaurs swam in the sea at the same time as the dinosaurs. On the beach I often find ammonites, which are curly shells turned to stone. I have drawn one for you.

My dog Tray comes fossil hunting with me. He is very patient while I dig.

Your friend from the seashore,

Mary

P.S. If you found a fossil on the beach, what would you hope it was?

REAL HISTORY

The true story behind Mary's letter, for Oliver and a grown-up to read together.

1. Mary Anning (born 1799) was a fossil hunter from Lyme Regis in Dorset, on the coast now called the Jurassic Coast.
2. Around 1811, her brother Joseph found the skull of an ichthyosaur, and Mary, aged about 12, found the rest of the skeleton.
3. Ichthyosaurs were sea reptiles that lived at the same time as the dinosaurs, but they were not dinosaurs themselves.
4. Scientists of her day often didn't give Mary credit for her discoveries. Today she is remembered as one of the greatest fossil hunters.
5. Storytelling: Mary never wrote to children in the future, but she really did have a dog called Tray who came fossil hunting with her.

Write back to Mary!

Write here or on any paper you like. Then ask a grown-up to take a photo of it and upload it in your Letters from History account. Mary's next letter will answer you.

$E = mc^2$

The Maya Family
1 Example Street
Bristol
BS1 4ST

Princeton, New Jersey

Dear Maya,

A most curious thing happened this morning. I sat down at my desk here in Princeton to think about the universe, and instead my pen began writing to you, a girl who lives many years in my future! I do not understand how this letter will reach you. But I have learned that the best mysteries are the ones we cannot yet explain.

I am told you love space. So do I! When I was about five years old, my father showed me a compass. No matter how I turned it, the little needle pointed the same way, as if an invisible hand were pushing it. I could not stop wondering what that invisible thing was. I think that wondering is where all my science began.

Here is something I worked out about space: it is not stiff and empty like a box. Heavy things, like the Sun, bend space around them, a little like a bowling ball sitting on a trampoline. Even light, the fastest thing there is, curves as it passes by. In 1919, astronomers watched starlight bend around the Sun during an eclipse, just as I had predicted. I was very pleased, and also a little relieved!

I hear you draw comics and have a cat named Biscuit. When I was sixteen, I liked to imagine pictures in my head, such as racing alongside a beam of light. Perhaps you and I think in the same way.

Now I must practise my violin before supper. Mozart is very patient with my mistakes. My neighbours, perhaps less so.

Your friend across time,

Albert

P.S. If you drew a comic about Biscuit travelling through space, what would happen in it? I would very much like to know.

REAL HISTORY

The true story behind Albert's letter, for Maya and a grown-up to read together.

1. Albert Einstein (1879–1955) was a physicist. From 1933 he lived and worked in Princeton, New Jersey, USA.
2. The compass story is true: Einstein later described how a compass his father showed him as a small boy filled him with wonder.
3. In 1915 Einstein explained gravity as the bending of space and time. In 1919, astronomers measured starlight bending around the Sun during a solar eclipse, and he became world-famous. The trampoline is our way of picturing it.
4. At about 16, he imagined chasing a beam of light. This 'thought experiment' helped lead him to his theory of special relativity.
5. Storytelling: Einstein never wrote to children in the future, and the joke about his neighbours is ours. But he really did play the violin all his life, and he answered letters from real children.

Write back to Albert!

Write here or on any paper you like. Then ask a grown-up to take a photo of it and upload it in your Letters from History account. Albert's next letter will answer you.

VIA AIR MAIL · PAR AVION

The Leo Family
1 Example Street
Bristol
BS1 4ST

Somewhere above the clouds

Dear Leo,

Thank you for your wonderful letter! A red Lego plane, just like my red plane? That made me smile all the way up to the clouds.

You asked if I was scared flying over the ocean all alone. Here is the truth: sometimes I was. The night was dark, a storm rumbled, and ice tried to stick to my wings. But I had practised and practised, and I knew my plane very well. Being brave does not mean you never feel scared. It means you keep going carefully, even when you do.

You also asked what I ate. On that long flight, I mostly sipped tomato juice through a straw! It kept me going for about fifteen hours, all the way to a farmer's field in Northern Ireland.

And you lost your first tooth! Congratulations, Leo. That is a big moment, a bit like a first flight.

Your friend in the sky,

Amelia

P.S. If you could fly your Lego plane anywhere in the whole world, where would you go?

REAL HISTORY

The true story behind Amelia's letter, for Leo and a grown-up to read together.

1. On 20–21 May 1932, Amelia Earhart became the first woman to fly solo nonstop across the Atlantic Ocean, in a red Lockheed Vega.
2. The flight took about 15 hours. She met storms and ice on the way, and landed safely in a farmer's pasture near Derry, Northern Ireland.
3. She reported that her only food on the flight was a can of tomato juice, sipped through a straw.
4. Storytelling: Amelia never wrote to children in the future. This letter imagines what she might say to Leo, using only true facts about her life.

Write back to Amelia!

Write here or on any paper you like. Then ask a grown-up to take a photo of it and upload it in your Letters from History account. Amelia's next letter will answer you.

Translated from the Greek

The Sofia Family
1 Example Street
Bristol
BS1 4ST

From the palace at Alexandria

Greetings, Sofia,

I am Cleopatra, Queen of Egypt, and I write to you from my palace in Alexandria, where the sea breeze smells of salt and the harbour is crowded with ships from many lands. My scribes tell me this letter will travel more than two thousand years to reach you. I have ruled a kingdom since I was about eighteen, yet I have never sent a message so far!

They tell me you love puzzles. Then you would enjoy Alexandria. Our great Library holds scrolls gathered from across the world, and scholars come here to study them. I speak many languages myself, and I am the first ruler of my family to learn the language of the Egyptian people. A queen should understand those she rules, don't you agree?

You also love swimming. Everything in Egypt depends on our river, the Nile. Each year it floods, and when the water sinks back it leaves rich, dark soil where our farmers grow wheat. That wheat makes Egypt wealthy. Even the paper I write on comes from the river: it is papyrus, made from a plant that grows along its banks.

From my window I can see the great Lighthouse, the Pharos, with its fire burning to guide sailors safely into the harbour at night. Sailors from every land speak of it with wonder.

With royal regards,

Cleopatra

P.S. If you could add one scroll to the Library of Alexandria, what would it be about?

REAL HISTORY

The true story behind Cleopatra's letter, for Sofia and a grown-up to read together.

1. Cleopatra VII became queen of Egypt in 51 BC, at about 18. Her family, the Ptolemies, were of Macedonian Greek origin and ruled Egypt for nearly 300 years.
2. Ancient writers say she spoke many languages, and she is reported to be the first ruler of her family to learn the Egyptian language.
3. The Lighthouse of Alexandria (the Pharos) became one of the Seven Wonders of the Ancient World, and the city's Library was famous for its collection of scrolls.
4. Most of what we know about Cleopatra was written by Greek and Roman writers long after she lived, so historians are careful with some stories.
5. Storytelling: Cleopatra wrote in Greek and never wrote to anyone in the future. This letter imagines what she might say, using true facts.

Write back to Cleopatra!

Write here or on any paper you like. Then ask a grown-up to take a photo of it and upload it in your Letters from History account. Cleopatra's next letter will answer you.

The Sam Family
1 Example Street
Bristol
BS1 4ST

Milan

Dear Sam,

Forgive the ink spots on this page. I write quickly when an idea is chasing me, and this morning one chased me all the way across Milan. I am Leonardo, from the little town of Vinci, and I am told you are an inventor. Then we are already friends.

When I was young, I learned my trade in the workshop of Master Verrocchio in Florence. We painted, carved and built machines, all under one roof. I learned there that artists and engineers must both do the same thing first: look very, very carefully.

These days I am filling my notebooks with birds. I watch how they tilt their wings to turn, and how they ride the wind without flapping. I have drawn many designs for a machine that might let a person fly. None of them flies yet. But each drawing teaches me something the last one did not.

If you ever see my notebooks, you will notice something strange: I write backwards, from right to left. I am left-handed, and it suits me. To read it, you need a mirror. I have written one line for you at the bottom of this page so you can try.

They also tell me you play a game where you kick a ball. I would very much like to draw how your leg moves when you kick it. Everything that moves has a secret, Sam. The fun is finding it.

Your fellow inventor,

Leonardo

P.S. What is the best invention you have ever dreamed up? Draw it for me if you can.

Hold this line up to a mirror. This is how I write in my notebooks!



REAL HISTORY

The true story behind Leonardo's letter, for Sam and a grown-up to read together.

1. Leonardo da Vinci was born in 1452 near Vinci, close to Florence, Italy. He was a painter, engineer and inventor.
2. As a teenager he trained in the workshop of the artist Andrea del Verrocchio in Florence.
3. He was left-handed and often wrote in mirror writing, from right to left. Thousands of pages of his notebooks survive today.
4. He studied how birds fly and drew designs for flying machines, but none were built as working machines in his time.
5. Storytelling: the ink spots and the idea chasing him across Milan are imagined, and Leonardo never wrote to anyone in the future.

Write back to Leonardo!

Write here or on any paper you like. Then ask a grown-up to take a photo of it and upload it in your Letters from History account. Leonardo's next letter will answer you.